

Terminal IDE Desktop

FRONTMATTER

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REFERENCE VIDEOS

- Claude Code CLI vs VS Code Extension: Which Should You Use? (<https://claude.com/faqs/claude-code-cli-vs-vscode-extension-comparison/>) -- ClaudeLog -- Read for the decision framework: what actually changes between the two interfaces and for whom
- CLAUDE CODE FULL COURSE 4 HOURS: Build & Sell (2026) (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QoQBzR1NIql>) -- Nick Saraev -- Watch for how Nick uses the terminal and when he switches -- his interface choices reveal real workflow priorities
- Claude is Taking Over: Every New Feature Explained (Full Guide) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_5xDx_IL9fQ) -- Independent creator -- Watch for how the Desktop and IDE integrations are framed against the terminal baseline

THE ONE THING

Terminal, IDE, and Desktop are three interfaces to the same Claude Code -- the one you pick is a workflow decision, not a capability decision, and picking the wrong one just adds friction.

HOOK

People argue about whether to use Claude Code in the terminal, an IDE, or Claude Desktop. Here is the actual answer -- based on what you are actually trying to do.

TARGET VIEWER

Someone who just installed Claude Code, discovered it can run in the terminal, VS Code, and Claude Desktop, and has no idea which one to actually use first.

PAYOFF

After watching, the viewer makes a confident, specific decision about which interface to start with based on their setup and goals -- and knows they can add or switch at any time.

BEAT STRUCTURE

Beat -- Three Interfaces, One Engine

Point: Terminal, IDE extension, and Desktop all connect to the same Claude Code engine -- the interface is about workflow fit, not capability or model quality.

Visual: Diagram: three UI options (terminal, VS Code panel, Desktop app) all connecting to a single Claude Code engine at the centre

Target words: ~100w

Beat -- Terminal -- Full Control, Zero Friction

Point: The terminal is the original interface: run claude in any folder, type your request, get output. Fastest to start, highest ceiling for advanced use, least visual.

Visual: Terminal window: run claude in a project folder, ask it to describe the project, output appears -- clean and fast

Target words: ~160w

Beat -- IDE Extension -- Visual Diffs, Daily Development

Point: The VS Code and JetBrains extensions add a chat panel, visual side-by-side diff review, and checkpoint rewind -- better for daily coding where you want to see changes before accepting.

Visual: VS Code with Claude Code extension: chat panel on the left, diff viewer on the right with accept/reject buttons on proposed file edits

Target words: ~170w

Beat -- Claude Desktop -- Beyond Code

Point: Claude Desktop runs Claude Code inside a GUI and integrates with Cowork -- best for document work, file operations, and non-code tasks where you want a desktop app experience.

Visual: Claude Desktop: dragging a folder of PDFs in, running a multi-step task, getting a deliverable -- no terminal in sight

Target words: ~150w

Beat -- Which One to Start With

Point: Start with the terminal for maximum flexibility and no dependencies. Add the IDE extension when you want visual diff review. Switch to Desktop when your tasks go beyond code.

Visual: Simple decision flowchart: what kind of work are you doing? Code in a project -> terminal or IDE. Document/file work -> Desktop.

Target words: ~130w

Beat -- CTA Bridge

Point: You know which interface fits your work. Next: CLAUDE.md -- the single file that teaches Claude everything it needs to know about your project before the first session starts.

Visual: Preview clip from CLAUDE.md Explained

Target words: ~60w

ANALOGY BANK

- Three interfaces: Like accessing email via browser, desktop app, and mobile. Same inbox, same messages, same account -- different experience optimised for different contexts and devices. You pick based on where you are and what you need to do.

- Terminal vs IDE extension: Like command line vs GUI for the same tool -- power users prefer the command line for control and speed; others prefer the GUI for the visual feedback and review capability.

THESIS LINE LOCATION

Beat 1 -- The insight is: arguing about which interface is best is the wrong question -- they solve different workflow problems, and using the right one for the right context is the only answer that matters.

FRAMEWORK PHRASE

Same engine, different wheel

SPECIFICITY BANK

- VS Code Claude Code extension: available in VS Code Marketplace, search "Claude Code"
- JetBrains extension: available for all JetBrains IDEs
- Terminal: claude command after npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
- Claude Desktop: downloadable from claude.ai for Mac and Windows
- IDE extension features: visual diff review, checkpoint rewind, @-mention file references, parallel conversations
- /ide command in terminal connects to VS Code for diff viewing while keeping terminal control

CONSTRAINTS

- Do not go into detailed setup of each interface -- keep it decision-framework focused
- Do not compare performance benchmarks or speed between interfaces
- Do not go into MCP server configuration -- that is a separate topic
- Do not list every feature of each interface -- pick the 2-3 that drive the decision

CTA DIRECTION

You have your interface. Next: CLAUDE.md -- the file that teaches Claude everything about your project so you never have to explain it again.

PERSONAL ANGLE [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: Which interface you actually use for different types of work -- and the moment you realised terminal and IDE serve different purposes rather than one being better.

VULNERABILITY MOMENT [DANIEL TO FILL]

Suggested: Spending weeks using the wrong interface for your workflow because you did not know alternatives existed -- and how different your experience became once you switched.

Note: belongs in Beat 5